



iOS location data collection drops

A new iOS 13 feature that reports app location tracking has reduced location data collection on iOS by 68%. <https://digit.in/feb20-73>



Pokémon ASMR

The Pokémon Company released two ASMR-styled Pokémon videos this week on YouTube. <https://digit.in/feb20-74>

Amazon Echo Flex

Compact in every way

It's becoming increasingly evident that Amazon wants to rule the roost in the Indian smart speaker and—more recently—small display markets. Amazon's aim is to make its popular digital assistant Alexa as easily accessible to the user as possible. This aim reflects unmistakably in the new Echo Flex. It costs ₹2,999 on Amazon.in but it's selling for ₹2,499 at the time of writing this review. With that, let's check out the new Echo Flex.

Build and design

The Amazon Echo Flex sports a unique form factor, which can't quite be compared with that of its brethren. The Echo Flex is unmistakably wall-mountable, which is both good and bad. It's good because it doesn't clutter your home with one more power cable and adaptor. It's bad because it forces you to use it directly from an easy-to-reach wall socket; a power strip that's tucked away, say, under your bed won't do much good.

Still, the Echo Flex can prove to be an attractive little piece of tech. In its compact rectangular white plastic shell, the device packs a tiny 0.6-inch speaker, a two-microphone array, the Action and Microphone Off buttons, a small LED light bar for status indications, a 3.5mm jack for audio output, and a USB-A port for charging other devices. While the short pill-shaped light bar doesn't fail to show the device's status, it's not as effective or attractive as the multi-colour light ring on the mainstream Echo series. The Echo Flex also misses physical volume buttons, forcing you to use your voice.

Features

Like most other devices in the Echo family, the Echo Flex features a 3.5mm jack for audio output. By contrast, none of Google's smart speakers or displays in India come with a 3.5mm jack for audio



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output. Surprisingly, the Echo Flex even packs a USB-A port on the bottom side of its body for charging low-power devices. Now, this is something we don't see on other Echo devices—not even on the most expensive Echo Studio. The USB port on the Echo Flex can deliver up to 7.5 watts, which is comfortable for charging wireless headsets and fitness bands. It's a nifty feature that won't go amiss on other Echo speakers as well.

UI

Like every other Echo device in Amazon's stable, the Echo Flex is powered by the Amazon Alexa voice-based digital assistant. Alexa lets you give her commands, but some commands will only work when a certain 'skill' is enabled in the Alexa app. When compared with Google Assistant, Amazon Alexa comes with a few unique features, such as whisper mode and a custom wake word setting. In our experience, Amazon Alexa is a friendlier digital assistant than Google Assistant.

Audio quality and voice response

The Echo Flex comes with a single tiny 0.6-inch mini-speaker that's best reserved for alarms, reminders, and voice

responses from Alexa. Its output is, at best, flat and weak for all genres of music. In fact, Amazon writes candidly on the product page, "Echo Flex has a mini built-in speaker that is not optimized for music playback." Luckily, there's a 3.5mm jack for output to external speakers. You should definitely connect the Echo Flex to a pair of good speakers if you seek good audio quality.

The Echo Flex uses a two-microphone array to pick up 'Alexa' calls from its users. The third-generation Echo, by contrast, employs a seven-microphone array. The microphone setup on the Echo Flex isn't bad, but it isn't great either. The review unit responded to 'Alexa' calls as expected when we sat about two metres away from the device and spoke with moderate softness. But the device failed to pick up our calls when we moved even a little farther away. In other words, the Echo Flex should be able to hear you if it's kept fairly close to you in the bedroom or kitchen.

Bottomline

The fact that the Amazon Echo Flex is a cable-free wall-mountable smart speaker is both an advantage and disadvantage. Which one of them it is to you depends on how you plan to use the Echo Flex. Also, the Echo Flex is strictly a near-field device due to its two-microphone array. Additionally, it's got a weak speaker that's only good for voice responses, making it disappointing for music playback—unless you've got a set of better external speakers to connect it to. It wins a few brownie points by offering a USB-A port for charging other devices. Overall, the Echo Flex is for you if you're aware of its physical limitations and want a cheap Echo device. Its biggest selling point is its budget-friendly price of ₹2,999.

—Vignesh Giridharan

SPECIFICATIONS

WEIGHT: 150 g | WI-FI CONNECTIVITY: Dual-band Wi-Fi supports 802.11 | CONNECTIVITY: A2DP, AVRCP | USB CONNECTIVITY: USB-A port for phone charging | DRIVER TYPE: full-range driver | DRIVER DIAMETER: 15mm | INTELLIGENT ASSISTANT COMPATIBLE: Alexa

CONTACT

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